

Link to [Royal Society URF webpage](#), including Scheme Notes and Terms and Conditions

SFI has recently formed a partnership with the Royal Society, whereby researchers can apply for a prestigious Royal Society University Research Fellowship, to be hosted by an eligible institution in the Republic of Ireland. Trinity College Dublin would like to invite applications from outstanding scientists at the early stages of their career, who have the potential to become world leaders in their field.

Fellowship applications spanning all areas of the life and physical sciences, including engineering, but excluding clinical medicine and any researcher addressing a direct biomedical research question*, are encouraged.

Fellowships are awarded initially for 5 years, with the possibility of a further 3-year extension.

Applicants must meet the following eligibility criteria:

- They must be in the early stages of their researcher career and must have **between 3 and 8 years of research experience since their PhD** (by the closing date of the round, 11 September 2014). **Note that the date used to qualify the 3 years from the closing date of the call is the date when the applicant first took up a postdoc position and not the date of the award of the PhD.** (For example, if an applicant received their PhD 10 years ago, went directly into industry post-PhD and then returned to a research/postdoc-type position three years ago, then they would be eligible to apply for an URF. The RS indicated at the Cork event that they support non-traditional career paths such as this).
- They **must not hold a permanent post in a university** or not-for-profit organisation in the European Economic Area (EEA).
- They **must be a citizen of the EEA**, a Swiss citizen or have worked in a research institution in the EEA in the last two years.

For full information, please read carefully the [Scheme Notes](#).

Funding Available

Royal Society-SFI University Research Fellowship awards consist of fellow's salary (at 'Research Fellow' level on [SFI's salary scales](#), and research costs (€15,000 in year 1, €13,000 for subsequent years). The URFs also offer the opportunity for the fellow to participate in a range of activities to support personal development (e.g. innovation course, media and communications training, URF conference).

Applicants from the Republic of Ireland will be assessed along with candidates from the UK through the normal Royal Society (RS) peer review process. Success rates are around 10% and the RS typically interviews twice as many as applicants as there are awards available. The RS appoint between 35 and 40 URFs per annum in UK-based institutions. Mark Ferguson, Director General of SFI, has indicated that SFI will fund as many additional Ireland-based applications as are competitive through the Royal Society's evaluation process.

Grants may be transferred between institution, and on completion of the URF, it is expected that fellows will be in a strong position to be considered for a permanent academic post.

The **assessment criteria** for these fellowships are as follows:

- **Scientific merit of the individual:** past achievements, research career to date, publication record, likely contribution to research field, future potential, likelihood of independence.
- **Host institution:** suitability, appropriate expertise/equipment, research environment.
- **Proposed research project:** quality and originality of proposed project, definition of research plan, likelihood of achieving goals.

The Proposal

For full information, please read carefully the [Scheme Notes](#).

Applicants are required to fill in a number of details in direct text entry fields in the e-GAP submission. *See “Important e-GAP information” on page 3 of Scheme Notes.*

It is worth getting started on your application in e-GAP as soon as possible; there is quite a bit of data entry that is time-consuming.

Besides these details, the main sections of the proposal consist of:

- a **Statement of Qualifications and Career**
- a list of **Publications** in reverse chronological order – *PDF file upload, min. font size Arial 10.*
- a **Personal Statement** – qualifications, research career to date and aspirations. Why will the fellowship be beneficial to you now? – *direct text entry of max. 3,500 characters including spaces. [A note on “Plain text entry”/direct text – we recommend that you write your text in a word processor. To check number of characters, (MS Word) click on the ‘Review’ tab, click on ‘Word Count’, this should display the numeric count for ‘Characters (with spaces)’ – this is the relevant count].*
- Enter **present basic salary** and salary enhancement details: If you are an existing employee of TCD and have a query on your salary/salary enhancements, please contact Aran O’Hara or Elaine Shaw in Payroll (oharaaa@tcd.ie or elshaw@tcd.ie). For **salary enhancement figures**, provide one figure (which is the total of PRSI + employer’s pension costs, see table below).
- **Research proposal:** nature of research, including aims and brief plan of the research. Description of methods and techniques, with milestones/timescales. **Min. font size Arial 10** and ensure document has a title. (**max. 3 page PDF upload/Plain text 12,000 characters**). **A PDF is recommended. Note that references are usually included within the 3 page limit and can be inserted at the end of the proposal in a slightly smaller font, but ensure that they are legible.**
- **Scientific abstract:** direct text entry of max. 1,800 characters (*including spaces*)
- Several fields for text entry where there are **Animal Licence** costs. (Applications using animals, with TCD as host institution, should include costs to cover Irish Medicine Board project authorisation annual fees. For queries on this, contact: Dr Laavanya Parthasarathi,

Administrative Officer/Research Support Officer, BioResources Unit for advice, at Trinity Biomedical Sciences Institute (TBSI), Trinity College Dublin (TCD) T : 00353-1-896 4554 & 00353-(087)-7378659 or E-mail : parthasl@tcd.ie)

- **Financial details:** these will be approved by the Research Office (research.office@tcd.ie) in the e-GAP system after you submit **(by 09:00 on 4 Sept)**. Fellow salary costs (as per SFI scales) are below:

FINANCIAL DETAILS section	€	€	€	€	€	
SALARY REQUEST	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3	Year 4	Year 5	Total
Fellow salary: SFI Level 3 scale						
Basic salary	51716	53245	54820	56442	56442	272665
<i>On-Costs</i> Pay-Related Social Insurance (PRSI) @10.75%	5559	5724	5893	6068	6068	29312
Employer's pension contribution @ 20%	10343	10649	10964	11288	11288	54532
Total on-costs (for 'Salary enhancement' figure)	15902	16373	16857	17356	17356	83844

Note also that the figure for **overheads** must be manually entered into the "Overhead costs/indirect costs" field. The rate is 30% of the total, less equipment costs. ("Estate costs" are not applicable to applicants to Ireland-based institutions).

When inputting the figures into 'Financial Details', you should select 'Duration' (5 years) first – only then will you be able to see the full 5 year budget field, into which you need to manually enter the figures.

An Excel sheet to assist applicants with the Financial Details section will shortly be available on RPAMS – please check back in the next few days.

- **Lay report:** A lay summary of your proposal. Explain why you have chosen to work in this area and what it is about your proposed research that you find particularly exciting, interesting or important. Explain wider potential impact and benefits to society of your proposed research. **Reviewers place significant importance on this section.** – *direct text entry of max. 3,500 characters including spaces*
- **Host organisation justification:** Statement justifying your choice of TCD as host institution – *direct text entry of max. 1000 characters (including spaces)*
- **Justification:** Fully justify all costs for equipment, travel, consumables, other expenses. – *direct text entry of max. 2000 characters.*

Submission

The application is submitted via the [Royal Society's e-GAP system](#) and applicants are advised to register as soon as possible and to carefully read the 'Application Guidance Notes' in the Scheme notes document.

Please note that the Research Office must approve applications in the system by the RS' deadline of 11th September. The normal internal requirement for Head of School sign-off will be fulfilled by the Head of School's supporting statement which must be provided by the Head of School by 18th September. Applicants should ensure that they enter the correct Head of School e-mail for applications to that school (there may be an Acting Head of School at the time, or a generic e-mail address for that Head of School – **CHECK WITH THE SCHOOL**). If you do not ensure that you enter the correct e-mail address, you may jeopardise your application.

Closing Date

The closing date/internal deadline for applications to TCD (by submission of a proposal through the Royal Society's e-GAP system) is **09:00 4 September 2014**.

N.B. Information required from other individuals for your application by 18th September

Please note that, as part of the application process, applicants will be asked to provide contact details of **two referees** and the **Head of School**. Heads of School (referred to in the scheme notes as "Head of Department") will then be asked to provide, on e-GAP by the 18th September, a short statement (*1,000 characters including spaces*) detailing the applicant's suitability for the school and setting out the Head of School's intentions for the applicant's career progression at TCD.

Two referees should provide confidential references for your application. See scheme notes for details.

THE ONUS IS ON THE APPLICANT TO (i) ADVISE THE HEAD OF SCHOOL AND REFEREES OF HER/HIS APPLICATION WELL IN ADVANCE OF 18th SEPT. , AND (ii) ENSURE THAT HEAD OF SCHOOL AND REFEREES ARE AWARE OF WHAT THEY NEED TO DO - SEND THEM APPENDIX 1 (of Scheme Notes).

Please see the Submission Process flow diagram on page 13 of the Scheme Notes for an overview of the process.

For further information, please contact: Ms Deirdre Caden, Trinity Research & Innovation, Trinity College Dublin. Email: cadend@tcd.ie or research.office@tcd.ie

Hints & Tips to increase your chances of success:

The proposal

- There should be a strong and original central hypothesis, with a research plan which shows a clear route to a clearly-defined overall goal.
- Explain the significance of the research question in a wider context (the big picture), and don't focus on technical details (you only have 3 pages)!
- Explain why your proposed research idea is timely – why now?

- The research proposal should strike the right balance, be feasible and not over-ambitious.
- Preliminary data should be convincing.
- Interdisciplinary research is encouraged.
- Evidence of knowledge of the area, and appropriate experience, should be demonstrated.
- It is important to consider and address how the research will affect the wider scientific community and society in general.
- Key individuals should be identified and included as part of the project.
- Get help from senior academic colleagues – ask them to read and comment on drafts of the 3-page proposal, personal statement and host organisation justification.

You

- Your USP: How are *you*, and your set of skills and experience, uniquely placed to solve this research problem?
- The vision is really important not just in terms of the scientific idea but in terms of becoming an independent researcher – what are your long-term aspirations, where do you see yourself in 5 years' time?
- Applicants should already show a level of independence – what collaborations have you established? Have you developed your own professional network? Highlight where you have organised conferences or reviewed papers, or taken on responsibility (for students, equipment, coordination of any courses, for example).
- Why is TCD the right place to do this Fellowship – what can it offer that other institutions in Ireland cannot?
- The application must be easy to understand and read. It should be **a joy to read** for the evaluators - the applicant's enthusiasm and passion for their research should be clearly communicated in the writing of the proposal, personal statement and lay report. The applicant should remember that the application will be reviewed by working scientists and not experts in the area, and so should keep this in mind when writing the proposal.

Other Information

- In relation to the **publication track record** of the applicant, there are no specific guidelines or rules. At the presentation in Cork, Alexander Thomson (RS) mentioned that the applicant could have three or twenty publications, and the assessment would not be based on the publication record of the applicant. **It is the overall application combined - the idea, the personal statement, the lay report, etc. that is evaluated.** (One of the audience members said that he had not been in a position to publish over the last few years as he was working in a commercially sensitive area, Alexander Thomson said that this would not go against the applicant once it was explained in the application).
- The RS actively encourages URF awardees to apply for **other awards and grants**, once the funding does not cover the URF's salary.
- As the purpose of the URF is to offer the Fellow protected research time, it would not be expected that the fellow would undertake more than ~ 6 hours of teaching per week (this

may increase in later years). For more information on this, please contact urf@royalsociety.org

- URFs must submit **annual reports** to the RS.
- If an applicant is not sure whether the RS will support their research area they can create an eGAP account and access a large list of subject groups and areas that are covered by this scheme. This can also be viewed in the [Royal Society Researcher database](#), where you can also view the profiles of previously successful URFs.

* The scheme no longer supports biomedical research. Applicants whose research is biomedical are instead encouraged to apply to the [SFI-HRB-Wellcome Trust Research Career Development](#) fellowship. (Where there is some doubt as to whether the proposed research addresses a direct biomedical question or not, the Royal Society has agreed to accept queries from applicants who email an abstract to urf@royalsociety.org).
